Bloom Filters in Networked Systems: Theory and Modern Applications

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Abstract

Bloom filters are space-efficient probabilistic data structures for approximate set membership queries. They guarantee no false negatives at the cost of a controllable false-positive probability. Originally introduced in the 1970s, Bloom filters have become a fundamental building block in networking, distributed systems, databases, and modern large-scale infrastructures. This paper surveys Bloom filters, expands on theoretical insights not fully developed in classical surveys, presents modern applications from recent literature, and presents a code implementation of the algorithm.

1 Introduction

A Bloom filter is a randomized data structure that compactly represents a set and supports membership queries with one-sided error: queries may return false positives but never false negatives. The original construction was introduced by Bloom [2] and later popularized in networking by Broder and Mitzenmacher [3].

The key motivation behind Bloom filters is a fundamental algorithmic trade-off: *trading exactness for space efficiency*. Whenever memory or communication bandwidth is constrained and false positives can be tolerated, Bloom filters often provide near-optimal performance.

The guiding principle, articulated by Broder and Mitzenmacher, is:

> *Wherever a list or set is used, and space is at a premium, consider using a Bloom filter if the effect of false positives can be mitigated.*

2 Bloom Filters: Mathematical Preliminaries

2.1 Standard Bloom Filters

A Bloom filter represents a set of n elements using a bit array of length m and k hash functions. Each of the k hash functions is designed to map elements to indices between 1 and m. To insert an element x, the k hash functions are applied on x and the corresponding bit positions, $h_i(x), i = 1, \ldots, k$, are set to one. To test membership, the same positions are checked: if any of the k bits is zero, we can infer with certainty that x is not in the set; if, on the other hand, all are one, x is *assumed* to be present. Indeed, because different elements may hash to the same positions, Bloom filters allow

false positives but never false negatives, with the error rate determined by the relationship between n, m, and k.

To better understand the performance of Bloom filters, we now analyze the probability of **false positives**—the situation in which the filter mistakenly reports an element as present when it is not. This false-positive probability is critical for designing and using Bloom filters effectively, as it directly impacts both the **memory efficiency** and **accuracy** of the filter. The following section provides a detailed mathematical analysis of how the false-positive probability behaves based on the parameters of the filter [2, 3].

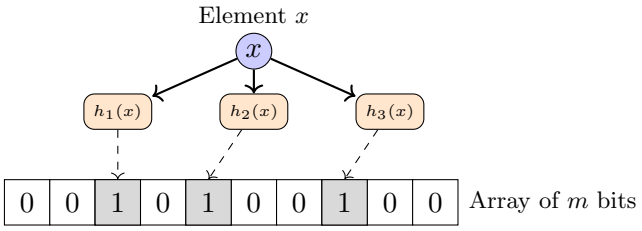


Figure 1: Structure of a Standard Bloom Filter with $k = 3$. The element x hashes to indices 2, 4, and 7.

2.1.1 Comparison with Hash Tables

It is important to distinguish Bloom filters from standard hash tables. A hash table requires the explicit storage of keys (or pointers to keys) to resolve collisions and verify membership. While the structural overhead per item is typically $O(1)$ slots, each slot must be large enough to store an identifier or a pointer, which typically scales with the size of the address space or the universe of items.

In contrast, a Bloom filter does not store the items themselves. It uses a *constant* number of bits per element (e.g., approximately $1.44 \log_2(1/\epsilon)$ bits/item for a false positive rate ϵ), regardless of the size of the items being represented. This property makes Bloom filters far more scalable for massive sets where the cost of storing even a fraction of the original keys would be prohibitive [3].

2.1.2 False Positive Probability

Assuming perfect randomness, the probability that a specific bit remains 0 after a single hash operation is $(1 - 1/m)$. After inserting n elements, each hashed k times, the exact probability q that a specific bit remains 0 is:

$$q = \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{kn} \tag{1}$$

Justification of the Exponential Approximation: This discrete probability can be simplified using the standard limit $\lim_{x\to\infty}(1 - 1/x)^x = 1/e$. By rewriting the expression as:

$$q = \left[\left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{m}\right]^{kn/m}$$

we see that as $m \to \infty$, the term inside the bracket approaches e^{-1}. Thus, we define the continuous approximation p as:

$$p = e^{-kn/m} \tag{2}$$

The distinction between q and p is important. The quantity q is the exact discrete probability and is therefore the correct quantity when we state precise expectations about the filter. The quantity p is an asymptotic approximation of q, and we use it when it yields cleaner closed-form expressions, such as in the optimization of k. For large m, the two values are very close, but it is still useful to keep both conceptually separate.

Let α denote the observed proportion of 0 bits in a concrete Bloom filter instance. Then $\mathbb{E}[\alpha] = q$.

The false positive rate f is defined as the probability that all k bit positions for a non-member element y are already set to 1. Using the approximation p:

$$f = (1 - \alpha)^k \approx (1 - p)^k = \left(1 - e^{-kn/m}\right)^k \tag{3}$$

2.1.3 Optimal Number of Hash Functions

Finding the optimal number of hash functions: To minimize the false positive rate f for fixed values of m and n, we minimize the expression $f = (1 - e^{-kn/m})^k$. It is mathematically convenient to minimize the natural logarithm of f:

$$\ln(f) = k \ln(1 - e^{-kn/m})$$

Let $p = e^{-kn/m}$ represent the approximated probability that a bit is 0. It follows that $\ln p = -kn/m$, which allows us to express k as $k = -\frac{m}{n} \ln p$. Substituting this back into the expression for $\ln(f)$:

$$\ln(f) = -\frac{m}{n} \ln p \ln(1 - p)$$

To find the minimum, we differentiate with respect to p and set the derivative to zero:

$$\frac{d}{dp} (\ln p \ln(1 - p)) = \frac{\ln(1 - p)}{p} - \frac{\ln p}{1 - p} = 0$$

$$(1 - p) \ln(1 - p) = p \ln p$$

By inspection, this equality holds when $1 - p = p$, implying $p = 1/2$. Substituting $p = 1/2$ back into the equation for k yields the optimal number of hash functions:

$$k_{opt} = \frac{m}{n} \ln 2 \tag{4}$$

At this optimal k, the false positive rate reaches its minimum:

$$f = (1/2)^k = (1/2)^{\frac{m}{n} \ln 2} \approx (0.6185)^{m/n} \tag{5}$$

Selecting an Integer k: In practice, the number of hash functions k must be an integer. Since the false-positive probability function (illustrated in Figure 2) is convex, the ideal integer k is found by testing the two integers nearest to k_{opt}: $\lfloor k_{opt} \rfloor$ and $\lceil k_{opt} \rceil$. One should calculate the resulting f for both values and select the one that yields the lower error rate. For example, if $k_{opt} = 5.7$, the correct procedure is to compare the values of f at $k = 5$ and $k = 6$ rather than automatically rounding to 6.

Because the false-positive probability function is relatively flat around its minimum point, the accuracy difference between these two integers is often small. Therefore, the choice can be guided by specific system requirements:

- **Round Down for Speed:** Choosing a smaller k reduces the number of hash calculations and memory probes required for each insertion and query.
- **Round Up for Safety:** If the system must strictly adhere to a maximum allowable false positive rate, rounding up provides a more conservative error boundary.

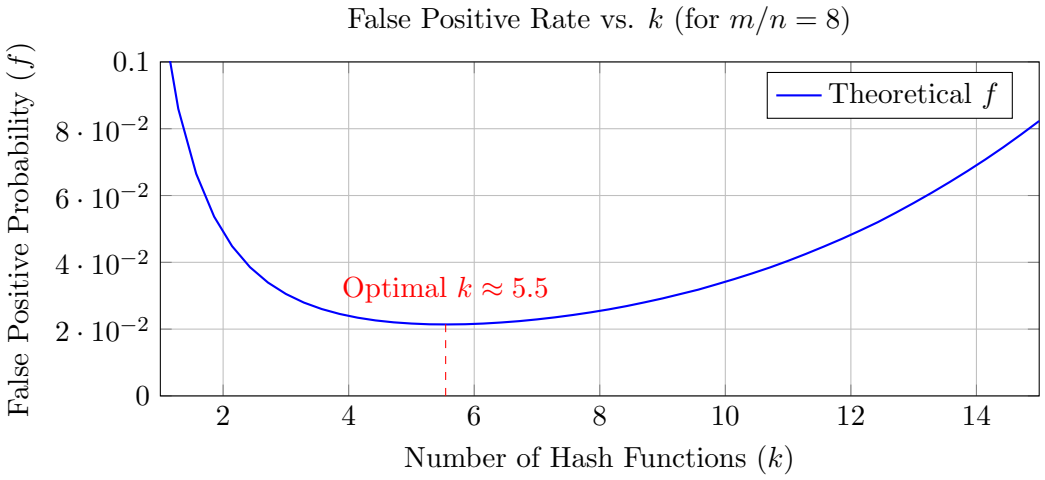


Figure 2: The False Positive Probability as a function of k (fixing $m/n = 8$). The error rate is minimized at $k = \frac{m}{n} \ln 2$.

2.2 A Lower Bound: The Information-Theoretic Limit

To properly evaluate the space efficiency of Bloom filters, we first ask a more fundamental question: even with the best possible data structure, how many bits are necessary to represent a set of size n drawn from a universe U of size u while allowing false positives at rate at most ϵ? This is an information-theoretic question, because it asks what is possible in principle before we commit to any particular construction.

Step 1: Count the number of possible sets. There are $\binom{u}{n}$ possible subsets of size n. Any membership data structure must somehow distinguish among all of these possibilities. If a representation uses only m bits, then it has at most 2^m distinct internal states.

If membership answers had to be exact, we would immediately need enough states to encode all $\binom{u}{n}$ sets. However, approximate membership allows false positives, so one internal state may legitimately correspond to more than one set.

Step 2: Understand what one state can represent. Fix one internal state of an approximate membership structure, and let A be the set of elements to which this state answers "present." If the state is used to represent a particular set X of size n, then two conditions must hold:

- every element of X must be accepted, because false negatives are not allowed, so $X \subseteq A$;
- among the $u-n$ elements not in X, at most an ϵ fraction may be accepted, so $|A \backslash X| \leq \epsilon(u-n)$.

Therefore,

$$|A| \leq n + \epsilon(u - n).$$

This means that one state can represent only sets X that are chosen as n-element subsets of some accepted set A of size at most $n + \epsilon(u - n)$. Hence, a single state can cover at most

$$\binom{n + \epsilon(u - n)}{n}$$

different sets.

Step 3: Cover all possible sets. Since there are at most 2^m states, and each state can represent at most $\binom{n+\epsilon(u-n)}{n}$ sets, all possible sets can be represented only if

$$2^m \cdot \binom{n + \epsilon(u - n)}{n} \geq \binom{u}{n}. \tag{6}$$

This is the key counting inequality behind the lower bound.

Step 4: Simplify the inequality. Assume now that the universe is much larger than the represented set, so $u \gg n$. Then

$$n + \epsilon(u - n) \approx \epsilon u.$$

Using the standard approximation $\binom{N}{K} \approx N^K/K!$ for large N and fixed K, we obtain

$$2^m \geq \frac{\binom{u}{n}}{\binom{n+\epsilon(u-n)}{n}} \approx \frac{\binom{u}{n}}{\binom{\epsilon u}{n}} \approx \frac{u^n/n!}{(\epsilon u)^n/n!} = \epsilon^{-n}.$$

Taking logarithms gives

$$m \geq -n \log_2 \epsilon = n \log_2(1/\epsilon). \tag{7}$$

This is the information-theoretic lower bound: no approximate membership data structure with false positive rate ϵ can asymptotically use fewer than $n \log_2(1/\epsilon)$ bits.

Comparing Bloom filters to the lower bound. We now compare this ideal lower bound with the actual cost of an optimal Bloom filter. From Section 2.1.3, at the optimal choice of k the false positive probability satisfies

$$\epsilon \approx (0.6185)^{m/n}.$$

Solving for m gives

$$\frac{m}{n} = \frac{\ln(1/\epsilon)}{\ln(1/0.6185)} = \frac{\ln(1/\epsilon)}{(\ln 2)^2}.$$

Equivalently,

$$m = \frac{n \ln(1/\epsilon)}{(\ln 2)^2} = \frac{n \log_2(1/\epsilon)}{\ln 2} \approx 1.44\, n \log_2(1/\epsilon). \tag{8}$$

Thus, an optimal Bloom filter uses only a factor of about 1.44 more space than the absolute information-theoretic minimum. This factor is small enough that Bloom filters are considered near-optimal in practice.

The significance of this comparison is conceptual as well as numerical. The lower bound says that the dependence on n and ϵ in Bloom filters is essentially the best possible. Bloom filters do not waste space by an order of magnitude; they are within a constant factor of the optimum, while still supporting simple updates and queries.

2.2.1 Efficiency of the 1.44 Factor

The derivation above shows that Bloom filters require approximately 1.44 times the space of the theoretical lower bound (a 44% overhead).

Explanation 1 (Why this is a good trade-off)**.** While it is possible to achieve the theoretical lower bound (factor of 1.0) using optimal compression or perfect hashing techniques, these methods come with significant practical drawbacks [3]:

- **Complexity:** Schemes like perfect hashing require knowing the set S in advance and involve complex pre-computation to find collision-free functions.
- **Static Nature:** Optimal schemes often cannot handle dynamic insertions without expensive re-computation.
- **Flexibility:** Bloom filters offer $O(1)$ insertion and lookup times with simple hash functions, regardless of the data distribution.

Thus, the factor of 1.44 is considered a negligible price for the simplicity, speed, and dynamic capabilities of the Bloom filter.

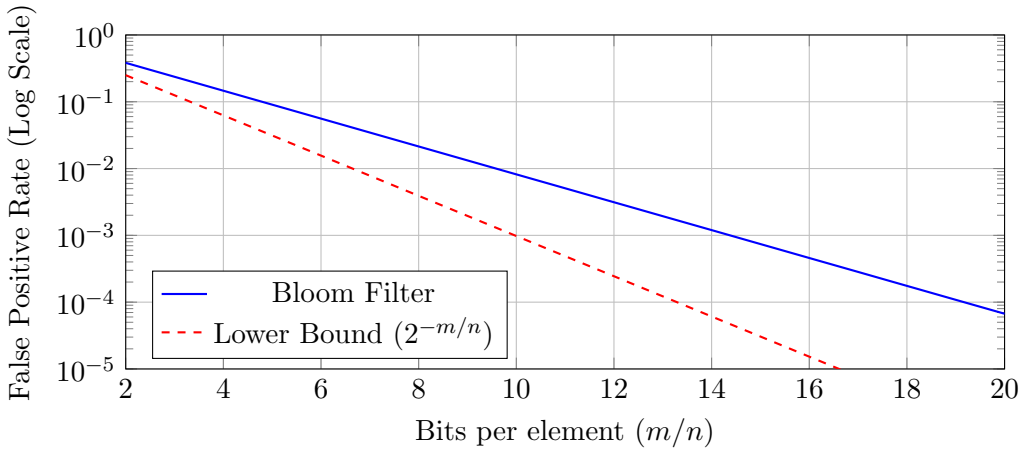


Figure 3: Comparison of Bloom Filter space efficiency versus the information-theoretic lower bound. Note the log scale on the y-axis.

2.3 Standard Bloom Filter Tricks

The simple structure of Bloom filters makes certain operations very easy to implement. When we compare two Bloom filters, B_1 and B_2, representing sets S_1 and S_2, we assume they use the same array length m, the same number of hash functions k, and the identical hash functions. Under this assumption, the bitwise inner product (the bitwise AND) of the two filters serves as a direct measure of their similarity.

Instead of computing the union first, Broder and Mitzenmacher demonstrated that the size of the intersection, $|S_1 \cap S_2|$, can be mathematically isolated by analyzing the probability of bits colliding in this inner product.

Step 1: The Expected Inner Product

To find the expected number of 1s in the bitwise AND filter, we must look at a single bit position j. A bit is set to 1 in *both* filters (thus becoming a 1 in the inner product) in one of two mutually exclusive ways:

1. **Directly via the intersection:** The bit is set by an element that belongs to $S_1 \cap S_2$.
2. **Coincidentally via distinct elements:** The bit is *not* set by the intersection, but it is set independently by some element unique to S_1 *and* some element unique to S_2.

Let $c = |S_1 \cap S_2|$. The probability of the first scenario is $1 - (1 - 1/m)^{kc}$. The probability of the second scenario requires the bit to be missed by the intersection $(1 - 1/m)^{kc}$, but hit by $S_1 \setminus (S_1 \cap S_2)$ and $S_2 \setminus (S_1 \cap S_2)$.

Combining these, the probability that the j-th bit is set in both filters is:

$$\left(1 - \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{kc}\right) + \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{kc} \left(1 - \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{k|S_1 \setminus S_2|}\right) \left(1 - \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{k|S_2 \setminus S_1|}\right) \tag{9}$$

By expanding this expression and multiplying by m (since there are m bits total), we obtain the expected magnitude of the inner product:

$$\mathbb{E}[\text{1s in AND}] = m\left(1 - \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{k|S_1|} - \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{k|S_2|} + \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{k(|S_1|+|S_2|-c)}\right) \tag{10}$$

Step 2: Transitioning to Zero-Counting

Solving this equation directly for the unknown c is algebraically difficult. However, just as analyzing empty bins is easier than analyzing full bins in probability, we can significantly simplify the math by observing the zero bits instead of the one bits.

Let Z_1 and Z_2 be the observed number of 0s in B_1 and B_2 (the bloom filters for Z_1 and Z_2), respectively. Let Z_{12} be the observed number of 0s in the inner product (the AND filter).

A bit is 0 in the inner product if it is 0 in B_1, or 0 in B_2, or both. By the principle of inclusion-exclusion, the number of 0s in the inner product is:

$$Z_{12} = Z_1 + Z_2 - Z_\vee$$

Where $Z_\vee$ is the number of 0s in the bitwise OR filter (which represents the union of the two sets). Rearranging this gives us a way to isolate the union's zeros:

$$Z_\vee = Z_1 + Z_2 - Z_{12}$$

To proceed with our estimation, we replace these observed zero counts with their theoretical expectations. *Broder and Mitzenmacher mathematically justify this direct substitution using a martingale argument and the Azuma-Hoeffding inequality; they demonstrate that the actual number of zero bits in a large Bloom filter is so tightly concentrated around its expected value that large deviations are exponentially unlikely.* Thus, we can safely substitute the expected values into our equations:

$$\mathbb{E}[Z_1] = m(1 - 1/m)^{k|S_1|}$$
$$\mathbb{E}[Z_2] = m(1 - 1/m)^{k|S_2|}$$
$$\mathbb{E}[Z_\vee] = m(1 - 1/m)^{k|S_1 \cup S_2|}$$

Broder and Mitzenmacher propose calculating the ratio $\frac{Z_\vee}{Z_1 Z_2}$ to isolate the intersection. If we substitute the expected theoretical values into this ratio, we see beautifully how the known set sizes cancel out:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{Z_\vee}{Z_1 Z_2} &= \frac{m(1-\frac{1}{m})^{k|S_1 \cup S_2|}}{m(1-\frac{1}{m})^{k|S_1|} \cdot m(1-\frac{1}{m})^{k|S_2|}} \\ &= \frac{1}{m}\left(1-\frac{1}{m}\right)^{k(|S_1 \cup S_2|-|S_1|-|S_2|)}\end{aligned}$$

Because $|S_1 \cup S_2| - |S_1| - |S_2| = -|S_1 \cap S_2|$ (or $-c$), the right side simplifies entirely to yield the final intersection formula:

$$\frac{1}{m}\left(1-\frac{1}{m}\right)^{-kc} \approx \frac{Z_1 + Z_2 - Z_{12}}{Z_1 Z_2} \tag{11}$$

Step 3: Solving for the Intersection ($c = |S_1 \cap S_2|$)

To make this formula operational in software, we simply solve this Equation:

$$c \approx -\frac{1}{k}\frac{\ln\left(m \cdot \frac{Z_1+Z_2-Z_{12}}{Z_1 Z_2}\right)}{\ln(1-1/m)} \tag{12}$$

Step 4: A Numeric Example

To prove the operational validity of the Equation, let us simulate a concrete scenario. Assume we configure our Bloom filters with $m = 10,000$ bits and $k = 4$ hash functions. We populate two sets where $|S_1| = 1,000$, $|S_2| = 1,000$, and they share exactly $c = 500$ common elements.

If we count the 0s in our arrays, probability dictates they will closely match their expectations:

- $Z_1 \approx 10000(1-1/10000)^{4000} \approx 6703$ zeros.
- $Z_2 \approx 10000(1-1/10000)^{4000} \approx 6703$ zeros.

The true union size is $1000 + 1000 - 500 = 1500$. Therefore, the expected number of 0s in the union ($Z_\vee$) is $10000(1-1/10000)^{6000} \approx 5488$ zeros. Knowing this, the number of zeros in our inner product (Z_{12}) will be:

$$Z_{12} = Z_1 + Z_2 - Z_\vee = 6703 + 6703 - 5488 = 7918 \text{ zeros.}$$

Now, pretending we only know the observed zeros ($Z_1 = 6703, Z_2 = 6703, Z_{12} = 7918$), we apply the ratio for c:

$$\frac{Z_1 + Z_2 - Z_{12}}{Z_1 Z_2} = \frac{5488}{6703 \times 6703} = \frac{5488}{44,930,209} \approx 0.000122145$$

We plug this ratio into (Equation (13)):

$$c \approx -\frac{1}{4}\frac{\ln(10000 \cdot 0.000122145)}{\ln(0.9999)}$$

$$c \approx -0.25\frac{\ln(1.22145)}{-0.000100005} \approx -0.25\frac{0.199997}{-0.000100005} \approx -0.25(-1999.87) \approx 499.96$$

The mathematical formula accurately recovers the intersection size of 500 elements, demonstrating how tracking standard zero-bit collisions in the inner product reliably predicts the exact overlap between the original datasets.

3 Bloom Filter Variants

3.1 Counting Bloom Filters

3.1.1 Motivation and Overview

Standard Bloom filters offer a powerful, space-efficient solution for testing set membership. However, they suffer from a fundamental limitation: they act as a static data structure once populated. In a standard Bloom filter, setting a bit to 0 to remove an element is unsafe, as that bit may have been set by other elements due to hash collisions. Consequently, standard Bloom filters cannot support the deletion of items, making them unsuitable for dynamic environments where elements are frequently added and removed.

To address this, [9] introduced the **Counting Bloom Filter (CBF)**. This variation extends the standard model by replacing the array of single bits with an array of m counters.

3.1.2 Mechanism

In a Counting Bloom Filter, the structure consists of an array C of m counters, initially all set to zero. The operations are defined as follows:

- **Insertion:** When an item x is added, the locations determined by the k hash functions, $h_1(x), \ldots, h_k(x)$, are identified. Instead of setting bits to 1, the counters at these indices are incremented by 1.
- **Deletion:** To delete an item x, the counters at the hashed indices $h_1(x), \ldots, h_k(x)$ are decremented by 1.
- **Query:** An element is considered to be in the set if and only if all counters at positions $h_1(x), \ldots, h_k(x)$ are greater than zero.

3.1.3 Usage and Benefits

The transition from bits to counters provides several key benefits that expand the applicability of Bloom filters:

1. **Support for Deletions:** The primary benefit is the ability to remove elements. This allows the filter to represent a dynamic set that changes over time, such as a list of currently active network connections or a sliding window of recent web queries.
2. **Collision Handling:** In a standard filter, we never know how many elements hashed to a specific bit. In a CBF, the counter value provides information about the number of elements hashed to that bucket, allowing for more detailed analysis of collision rates.
3. **Scalability:** While CBFs require more space (usually 3-4 bits should suffice [9]) compared to the 1 bit per bucket of a standard filter, they prevent the need to rebuild the entire filter from scratch when the set content changes significantly.

To prevent overflow in counters, we bound the probability that a counter reaches value j. The probability a specific counter is incremented exactly j times is binomial [9]:

$$P(c(i) = j) = \binom{nk}{j} \left(\frac{1}{m}\right)^j \left(1 - \frac{1}{m}\right)^{nk-j}$$

Bounding the overflow probability. We use the standard bound $\binom{n}{k} \le (\frac{ne}{k})^k$, which gives

$$\binom{nk}{j} \le \left(\frac{nk \cdot e}{j}\right)^j.$$

Also, $(1 - 1/m)^{nk-j} \le 1$. Therefore,

$$P(c(i) \ge j) \approx \binom{nk}{j}\frac{1}{m^j} \le \left(\frac{nke}{j}\right)^j \frac{1}{m^j} = \left(\frac{nke}{jm}\right)^j.$$

If we further use the near-optimal regime $k \ge \frac{m}{n}\ln 2$, then

$$P(c(i) \ge j) \le m\left(\frac{e\ln 2}{j}\right)^j.$$

If we allow 4 bits per counter, the counter will overflow if and only if some counter reaches the value 16. From the above we have [3]:

$$P(\max c(i) \ge 16) \le 1.37 \times 10^{-15} \times m.$$

- **Overflow Probability:** Applying the union bound over the lifetime of the filter, the probability that an overflow occurs while the structure represents any one of t different set states (each of size at most n) is upper bounded by $1.37 \times 10^{-15} \times mt$. Here, "$t$ different sets" does *not* mean one larger set formed by taking their union. Rather, it means that the same counting Bloom filter may represent many different snapshots over time as insertions and deletions occur. For example, representing four successive sets of sizes $10, 20, 15, 30$ is a temporal sequence of four states, not the same task as representing one static set of size 75. The union bound asks for the probability that an overflow happens in *any* of those states. This low probability is sufficient for most practical applications.

- **Counter Size:** When the total number of increments is $m\ln 2$, the maximum counter value is $O(\log m)$ with high probability. Hence, the number of bits required per counter is only $O(\log\log m)$.

- **Handling Overflow:** In practice, when a counter does overflow, one approach is to leave it at its maximum value. This can cause a later false negative only if eventually the counter goes down to 0 when it should have remained nonzero. If the deletions are random, the expected time to this event is relatively large.

3.2 Compressed Bloom Filters

In many networking and distributed-system scenarios, Bloom filters are not only stored locally but also transmitted frequently across the network. While standard Bloom filters are already space-efficient, their raw bit-vector representation may still incur significant communication overhead when exchanged repeatedly or at large scale.

Compressed Bloom filters, introduced by Mitzenmacher [3], address this issue by exploiting the fact that a Bloom filter's bit array can be made very sparse (mostly zeros) and thus highly compressible. The core idea is to deliberately construct a Bloom filter with a larger bit array than strictly necessary, resulting in a lower fraction of bits set to 1, and then apply a general-purpose compression algorithm before transmission.

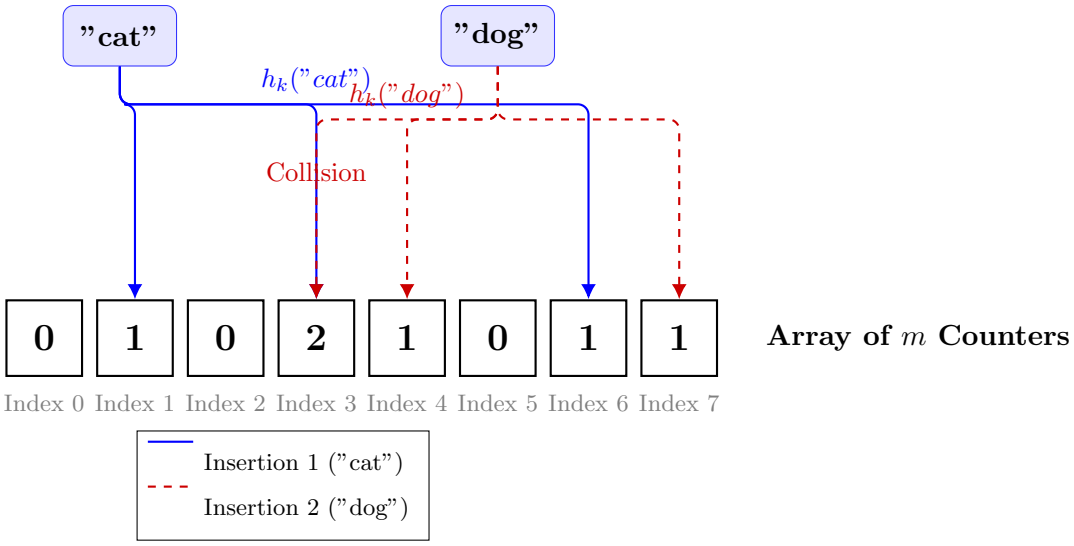


Figure 4: Structure of a Counting Bloom Filter. Elements are hashed to k positions, incrementing the corresponding integers in the counter array. Note index 3, where a collision results in a counter value of 2.

3.2.1 Theoretical Justification

To understand why this works, consider the standard parameter selection. When k is optimized to minimize the false positive probability for a fixed array size m, the probability of any specific bit being set is $p \approx 1/2$. Consequently, the bit array essentially resembles a random string of 0s and 1s with maximum entropy. It would therefore seem that compression cannot offer any gain.

Mitzenmacher demonstrates the flaw in this reasoning. The standard approach optimizes the false positive rate constrained by the *uncompressed* size m. However, if we optimize under the constraint of the *transmitted* (compressed) size z, the landscape changes. It turns out that using a significantly larger array size m (where $m \gg n$) but employing fewer hash functions k results in a very sparse filter. This sparse filter is highly compressible.

Remarkably, this "larger but sparser" strategy can satisfy the same transmission budget z while yielding a lower false positive rate than the standard dense filter.

3.2.2 Construction and Mechanism

A compressed Bloom filter is built in two phases:

1. **Construction:** A Bloom filter is initialized using a larger number of bits per element than would normally be optimal. This produces a sparse bit vector with a low density of 1s.

2. **Compression:** The bit vector is compressed using a standard compression scheme (e.g., run-length encoding or arithmetic coding).

The compressed representation is transmitted over the network and decompressed at the receiver before queries are performed. Importantly, compression does not affect correctness: decompression restores the exact Bloom filter bit pattern, preserving the same false-positive behavior.

3.2.3 Performance Trade-off

Table 1 illustrates this trade-off. In the uncompressed case (Column 1), we use $m/n = 16$ and $k = 11$, resulting in a false positive rate $f \approx 4.59 \times 10^{-4}$. By increasing the array size to $m/n = 48$ but reducing k to 3 (Column 3), the filter becomes sparse enough to be compressed down to $z/n \approx 15.8$ bits per element—fitting within the original bandwidth budget—while reducing the false positive rate to $f \approx 2.22 \times 10^{-4}$, a roughly 2× improvement.

Table 1: Comparison of Bloom Filter parameters when constraining transmission size. By allowing the uncompressed array (m) to be larger and sparser, the false positive probability (f) is reduced for the same transmitted size (z).

Parameter	**Standard**	**Intermediate**	**Optimized**
Array bits per element (m/n)	16	28	48
Transmission bits per element (z/n)	16	15.846	15.829
Hash functions (k)	11	4	3
False positive probability (f)	0.000459	0.000314	0.000222

3.2.4 Applications

Compressed Bloom filters are especially useful in systems where the cost of transmission dominates the cost of local computation:

- **Distributed caching systems** that periodically exchange summaries of cached content.
- **Peer-to-peer overlays** where membership information must be broadcast to neighbors.
- **Network measurement infrastructures** that share compact traffic summaries.

In such systems, the additional CPU cost of compression and decompression is typically negligible compared to the savings in bandwidth, making this a practical and effective optimization.

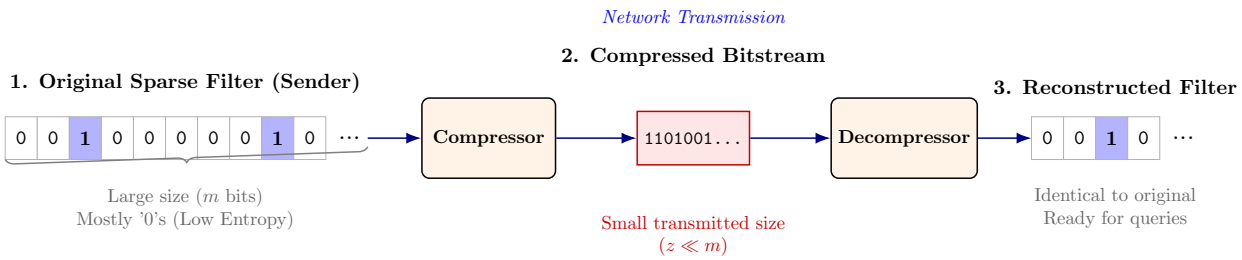


Figure 5: The lifecycle of a Compressed Bloom Filter. The original filter is intentionally constructed to be sparse (mostly zeros). This low entropy allows it to be significantly compressed for bandwidth-efficient network transmission. The receiver decompresses the stream to reconstruct the exact original filter state for querying.

3.3 Spectral and Scalable Bloom Filters

Standard Bloom filters are designed for static sets and simple membership queries. However, many real-world applications require either tracking element frequencies or handling sets whose size is not

known in advance. Spectral and scalable Bloom filters extend the basic data structure to address these limitations.

Spectral Bloom Filters. Spectral Bloom filters, introduced by Cohen and Matias [5], extend Bloom filters to support approximate frequency queries over multisets. Instead of storing a single bit per position, a spectral Bloom filter maintains counters, similar to a counting Bloom filter, but with a structure optimized for frequency estimation.

Each insertion increments the counters associated with an element's hash positions. The estimated frequency of an element is obtained by taking the minimum value across those counters. While collisions may cause overestimation, spectral Bloom filters provide probabilistic guarantees on the magnitude of the overestimation error in the reported element frequency.

A small example using network flows makes the idea clearer. Suppose packets from source IP `192.0.2.10` hash to counters $2, 5, 9$ and packets from IP `198.51.100.5` hash to counters $5, 7, 9$. If a router observes three packets from `192.0.2.10` and one packet from `198.51.100.5`, then counters $2, 5, 9$ are incremented three times by the first IP, while counters $5, 7, 9$ receive one additional increment from the second IP. The resulting counter values at the touched positions are therefore

$$C[2] = 3, \qquad C[5] = 4, \qquad C[7] = 1, \qquad C[9] = 4.$$

To estimate the packet volume of `192.0.2.10`, we take the minimum of its counters, namely $\min\{3, 4, 4\} = 3$, which is correct in this example. For `198.51.100.5`, we get $\min\{4, 1, 4\} = 1$. The important point is that collisions can only increase counters, so the estimate may be too large but never too small. This is the main distinction from an ordinary counting Bloom filter: the spectral version is designed not merely to support deletions, but to answer approximate frequency queries.

These structures are particularly useful in applications such as:

- Network traffic analysis (e.g., identifying heavy flows)
- Data-stream mining
- Approximate counting of frequently occurring items

Spectral Bloom filters trade exact frequency counts for significant reductions in memory usage, making them suitable for high-speed streaming environments.

Scalable Bloom Filters. Scalable Bloom filters, proposed by Almeida et al. [1], address a different problem: the need to represent a set whose size is not known in advance. A standard Bloom filter requires an estimate of the number of elements to achieve a desired false-positive rate; if this estimate is exceeded, performance degrades.

A scalable Bloom filter consists of a sequence of Bloom filters with increasing sizes and progressively tighter false-positive bounds. When the current filter reaches capacity, a new filter is added rather than resizing the existing one. Queries check all filters in sequence.

This approach guarantees that the overall false-positive probability remains bounded, while allowing the data structure to grow dynamically.

Scalable Bloom filters are particularly useful in:

- Long-running systems with unknown workloads
- Databases and storage engines
- Web crawling and indexing applications

Together, spectral and scalable Bloom filters demonstrate how the original Bloom filter concept can be extended to support richer query semantics and dynamic workloads while preserving probabilistic efficiency.

4 Historical Applications

Before their widespread adoption in modern networking and distributed systems, Bloom filters were employed in several pioneering applications that demonstrated their utility for space-constrained environments. These early use cases established the fundamental design patterns still in use today.

4.1 Spell Checkers

One of the earliest applications of Bloom filters was in the design of memory-efficient spell checkers for personal computers in the 1980s. At the time, main memory was severely limited, often measuring in kilobytes. A dictionary of valid English words could easily exceed available RAM if stored as a full list of strings.

To solve this, a dictionary of valid words was hashed into a Bloom filter. When a user typed a word, the system checked the filter:

- If the check returned **negative**, the word was certainly misspelled (not in the dictionary).
- If the check returned **positive**, the word was accepted as valid.

Although false positives meant that some misspelled strings (e.g., "speling") might be flagged as correct, the error rate could be tuned to be negligible. This allowed spell checkers to run entirely in fast memory without expensive disk lookups.

4.2 Distributed Databases

In the early 1990s, Bloom filters were adopted in distributed database systems to reduce communication overhead during distributed joins.

Consider a "semi-join" operation where a site A needs to send rows to site B that match keys present in B. Instead of sending all potential candidate rows from A to B (which wastes bandwidth) or sending all keys from B to A (which exposes the full index), site B would construct a Bloom filter of its keys and transmit it to A. Site A would then scan its table and only transmit rows whose keys matched the filter. This drastically reduced network traffic by filtering out non-matching tuples at the source.

4.3 Web Cache Sharing

As the World Wide Web grew in the late 1990s, the "Summary Cache" protocol utilized Bloom filters to enable web proxies to share cache content summaries efficiently. Rather than broadcasting full lists of cached URLs, proxies exchanged Bloom filters representing their cache contents. This allowed a proxy to quickly determine if a requested page resided in a neighbor's cache without the latency of a direct query or the bandwidth cost of full directory replication. This application laid the groundwork for the modern content delivery network (CDN) architectures discussed in Section 5.

5 Applications in Networking

5.1 Distributed Caching

Distributed web caching systems aim to reduce latency and bandwidth consumption by allowing multiple caches to cooperate and share content. A central challenge in such systems is determining which cache is likely to store a requested object without incurring excessive communication overhead.

To address this, cooperating web caches exchange Bloom filter summaries of their stored objects, commonly referred to as *cache digests* [9, 3]. A cache digest is a Bloom filter that encodes the set of URLs or object identifiers currently stored in a cache. Rather than transmitting full object lists, which may contain millions of entries, each cache periodically broadcasts its digest to peers.

When a cache receives a client request, it first checks the locally stored digests of neighboring caches. If a digest indicates that another cache *might* contain the requested object, the request is forwarded there. If the digest indicates non-membership, the cache avoids an unnecessary query entirely.

False positives in this setting result in a cache forwarding a request to a peer that does not actually hold the object. Importantly, such false positives incur a minor overhead: an extra network round-trip and a negative response. In contrast, the absence of false negatives ensures that a cache never fails to forward a request when a peer does have the object.

The bandwidth savings achieved by cache digests are substantial. Exchanging Bloom filters requires less data than sharing explicit object lists, especially in large-scale systems with frequent cache updates. As a result, the cost of occasional false positives is outweighed by the reduction in traffic, making Bloom-filter-based cache digests an effective mechanism for cooperative caching.

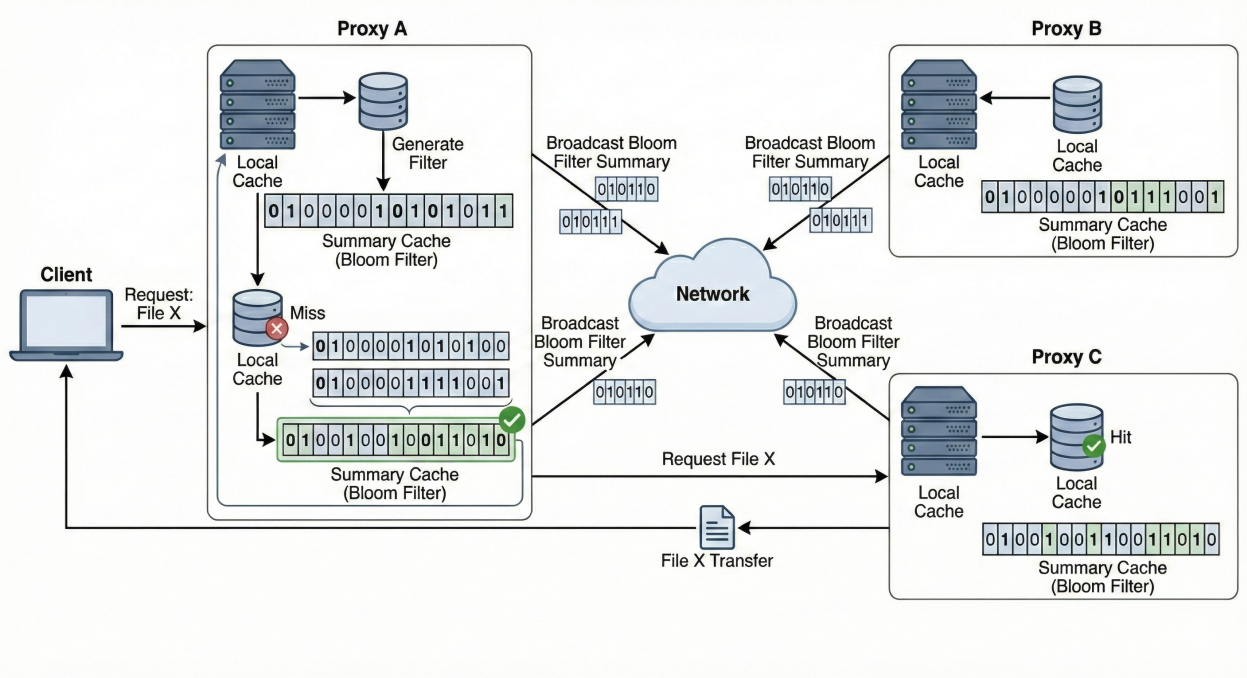


Figure 6: Distributed Web Caching mechanism. Proxy servers periodically broadcast Bloom filters summarizing their cache contents. When a cache miss occurs (e.g., at Proxy A), the proxy checks its neighbors' filters. If a match is found (Proxy C), the request is forwarded, saving bandwidth compared to broadcasting queries to all neighbors.

5.2 Peer-to-Peer and Resource Discovery

Bloom filters have also been widely adopted in peer-to-peer (P2P) systems to support efficient resource discovery without centralized indexes. A notable example is the *PlanetP* system [3][6], which demonstrates how Bloom filters can replace expensive global directories in moderately sized P2P networks.

PlanetP is a content-sharing system designed for environments with tens to hundreds of relatively stable nodes. Instead of using a distributed hash table, PlanetP relies on gossip-based dissemination of metadata. Each peer constructs a Bloom filter summarizing the set of documents or resources it stores and periodically exchanges this summary with other peers.

Over time, each node accumulates Bloom filter summaries representing the content available across the network. When a peer issues a query, it checks these filters to identify which peers are likely to contain the requested resource and directs the query accordingly.

False positives may cause a query to be sent to a peer that does not actually have the resource, but this only results in a small number of wasted messages. The benefit is a highly scalable and decentralized discovery mechanism that avoids maintaining exact global state. PlanetP illustrates how Bloom filters enable efficient, probabilistic resource discovery in peer-to-peer systems where bandwidth and coordination costs must be minimized.

5.3 Packet Routing and Forwarding

Bloom filters have been applied to packet routing and forwarding to reduce per-router state (information that each router must store and maintain locally for individual flows, destinations, or network entities.) and enable fast, scalable forwarding decisions. A particularly illustrative example is their use in multicast routing and stateless forwarding.

In Bloom-filter-based forwarding schemes, each link or forwarding interface in the network is assigned a unique identifier. To represent a multicast distribution tree, the identifiers of all links that should forward a packet are inserted into a Bloom filter. This Bloom filter is then embedded directly into the packet header.

When a router receives a packet, it checks the Bloom filter against the identifiers of its outgoing interfaces. If an interface identifier matches the Bloom filter, the packet is forwarded on that interface. This process eliminates the need for routers to maintain per-flow or per-group forwarding tables; all necessary forwarding information is carried within the packet itself.

False positives in this context may cause a packet to be forwarded along an unintended link. However, such events are typically rare if the Bloom filter parameters are chosen appropriately. Moreover, unintended forwarding usually results only in minor overhead, such as a packet being discarded by a downstream router or host.

The key advantage of this approach is the drastic reduction in routing state maintained at each router. By trading a small probability of extra packet transmissions for stateless forwarding, Bloom-filter-based routing schemes achieve high scalability and fast forwarding decisions, making them attractive for multicast, publish-subscribe, and information-centric networking architectures.

5.4 Queue Management and Congestion Control

This is one of the most instructive networking applications of Bloom-filter variants because it connects the probabilistic structure directly to a concrete systems problem: congestion control under strict memory constraints.

5.4.1 The Problem: Non-Responsive Flows

In any network, routers have limited memory buffers to hold packets waiting to be forwarded. Most network protocols (like TCP) are "polite": if they detect that the router is busy (congestion), they slow down. However, some traffic streams—known as *non-responsive flows*—refuse to slow down, flooding the router and starving well-behaved connections.

Identifying these is difficult. A high-speed router processes millions of flows simultaneously. Maintaining a specific record (state) for every single flow to check its behavior is computationally too expensive and requires too much memory.

5.4.2 The Solution: Stochastic Fair Blue (SFB)

To solve this, Feng et al. introduced *Stochastic Fair Blue (SFB)* [10]. This algorithm uses a **Counting Bloom Filter** to identify bad flows probabilistically, without needing a list of all active connections.

The Intuition. Imagine a system of buckets. When a packet arrives, we mistakenly assign it to k different buckets based on its flow ID. We don't know exactly who owns which bucket, but we monitor the buckets' health:

- If a bucket is overflowing (congested), we increase its "suspicion level."

- If a bucket is empty (idle), we decrease its "suspicion level."

A non-responsive flow is aggressive; it will continuously fill up *every* bucket it touches, raising the suspicion level of all of them to nearly 100%. A normal flow might unluckily share one bucket with a bad flow, but its other buckets will likely remain healthy. Therefore, if we see a flow mapped to k buckets that are *all* highly suspicious, we can confidently penalize it.

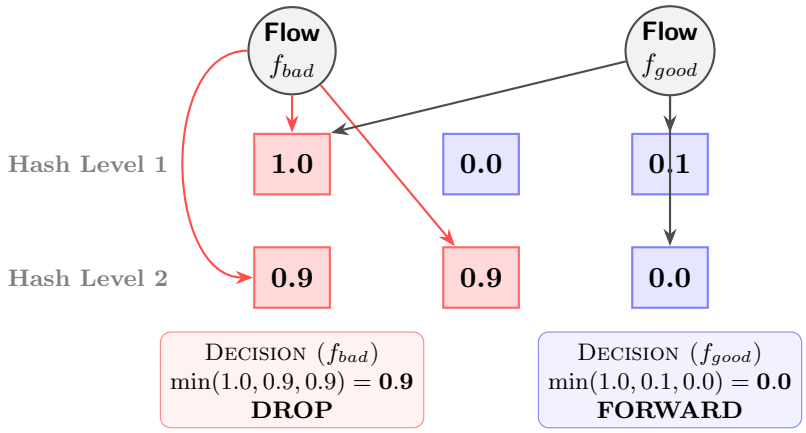


Figure 7: The Stochastic Fair Blue (SFB) mechanism. The minimum function allows the router to distinguish between an aggressive flow (f_{bad}) that pollutes all its hash buckets and a normal flow (f_{good}) that suffers a collision but remains clean in other buckets.

5.4.3 Algorithm Mechanism

Formally, the router maintains k levels of accounting bins (the Bloom filter). Instead of counting packets, each bin maintains a *marking probability* p_m, which represents the likelihood that traffic mapping to this bin should be dropped or marked as congested.

1. **Packet Arrival:** When a packet arrives, the router hashes its Flow ID (e.g., Source IP, Destination IP) using k hash functions to find k corresponding bins.
2. **Update (The Learning Phase):** The router monitors its physical queue size:
   - If the queue is too full, it increments p_m in the hashed bins (increasing suspicion).
   - If the queue is empty, it decrements p_m (decreasing suspicion).
3. **Decision (The Filtering Phase):** The router calculates the probability of dropping/marking the packet. Crucially, this is the **minimum** of the values in its k bins:

$$P_{drop} = \min(p_{m_1}, p_{m_2}, \ldots, p_{m_k})$$

Why the Minimum Matters. This *minimum* rule is the safety mechanism.

- **The Offender:** A bad flow sends so much traffic that it pollutes *all* k of its bins. The minimum of k high values is still a high value, so the flow is penalized.

- **The Victim:** A well-behaved flow might accidentally hash to the same bin as a bad flow (a collision). That specific bin will have a high p_m. However, the well-behaved flow also maps to $k-1$ other bins. Since the flow itself isn't sending excessive traffic, those other bins will likely have low p_m. Taking the *minimum* effectively ignores the polluted bin and allows the good traffic to pass through unharmed.

This application demonstrates the power of Bloom filters: they allow the system to manage complex per-flow states using a fixed, small amount of memory, trading absolute precision for statistical reliability.

5.5 Loop Detection in Packet Forwarding

While standard IP protocols use a Time-To-Live (TTL) field to eventually kill looping packets, this mechanism reacts slowly, often allowing packets to consume bandwidth for many hops before being discarded. Whitaker and Wetherall proposed using small Bloom filters carried within packet headers to provide immediate loop detection, a technique utilized in the *Icarus* system [14].

In this scheme, each node in the network is assigned a unique bitmask. As a packet traverses the network, it carries a small Bloom filter accumulating the masks of the nodes it has visited:

- Upon arrival, a router checks if its mask is already present in the packet's filter.
- If the router's bits are already set, a loop is suspected, and the packet can be discarded or flagged for creating a forwarding loop.
- If not, the router ORs its mask into the filter and forwards the packet.

Unlike TTL, which counts hops, the Bloom filter tracks *path history*. A false positive here—where a packet is incorrectly flagged as looping due to hash collisions—results in a dropped packet. However, for small networks or experimental protocols where loops are destructive, the trade-off favors immediate detection over occasional packet loss.

5.6 IP Traceback and Forensics

In the wake of Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS) attacks, network administrators often need to trace malicious packets back to their source. Snoeren et al. proposed the *Source Path Isolation Engine (SPIE)* [13], which utilizes Bloom filters to log packet digests at routers for historical auditing.

In SPIE, routers maintain a Bloom filter representing the set of all packets forwarded within a recent time window. When a traceback request is issued for a specific packet:

- The system queries the Bloom filters of routers in the network to see if they processed the packet.
- A positive match allows the system to construct a "traceback graph" rooted at the victim.

Because Bloom filters allow false positives, a router might mistakenly claim it saw a packet, creating a false branch in the traceback graph. However, by keeping the false positive rate low, the branching factor remains manageable, allowing for effective forensic analysis without the prohibitive storage cost of full packet logging [13].

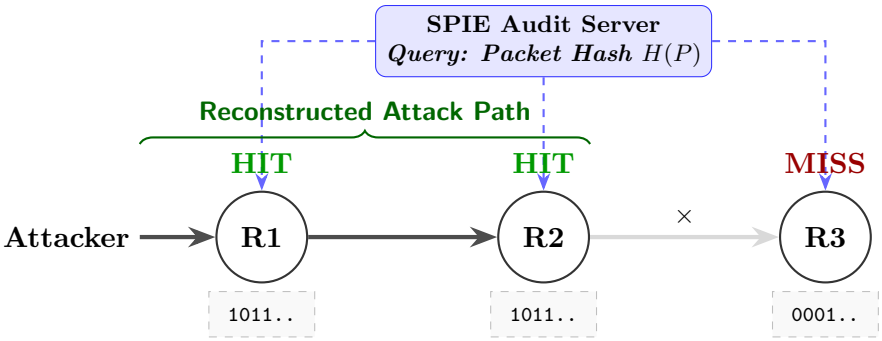


Figure 8: Forensic reconstruction using Source Path Isolation Engine (SPIE). The central audit server queries the Bloom filters of network routers. A positive series of matches ("HIT") allows the administrator to trace the packet's traversal path backward from the victim to the source.

6 Modern Applications

6.1 Large-Scale Storage Engines

Modern large-scale storage systems are designed to manage massive datasets that cannot fit entirely in main memory and therefore rely heavily on disk-based storage. Systems such as *Bigtable*, *RocksDB*, and *Apache Cassandra* exemplify this design paradigm [4][8][12].

Bigtable is a distributed, column-oriented storage system developed by Google to support large-scale applications such as web indexing and analytics [4]. RocksDB is a high-performance embedded key–value store optimized for flash storage [8], while Cassandra is a distributed NoSQL database designed for high availability and horizontal scalability [12]. Despite architectural differences, these systems share a common challenge: disk accesses are orders of magnitude slower than memory accesses, making unnecessary disk reads a major performance bottleneck.

To mitigate this cost, such systems organize data into immutable on-disk structures. Before accessing an on-disk file, the system must determine whether the requested key is present. Performing a disk lookup for every negative query would significantly degrade performance.

Bloom filters provide an efficient solution by acting as probabilistic pre-filters. Each on-disk data structure maintains a Bloom filter summarizing the keys it contains. When a lookup is issued, the Bloom filter is queried first. If the filter indicates non-membership, the system can safely skip the disk read entirely. If the filter returns a positive result, a disk access is performed to retrieve or confirm the key.

False positives may result in unnecessary disk reads, but the false-positive rate can be tuned to be very low. The cost of these occasional extra reads is negligible compared to the performance gains achieved by avoiding the vast majority of negative disk accesses. As a result, Bloom filters are a critical component in modern storage engines and play a key role in enabling scalable, read-efficient data access [3].

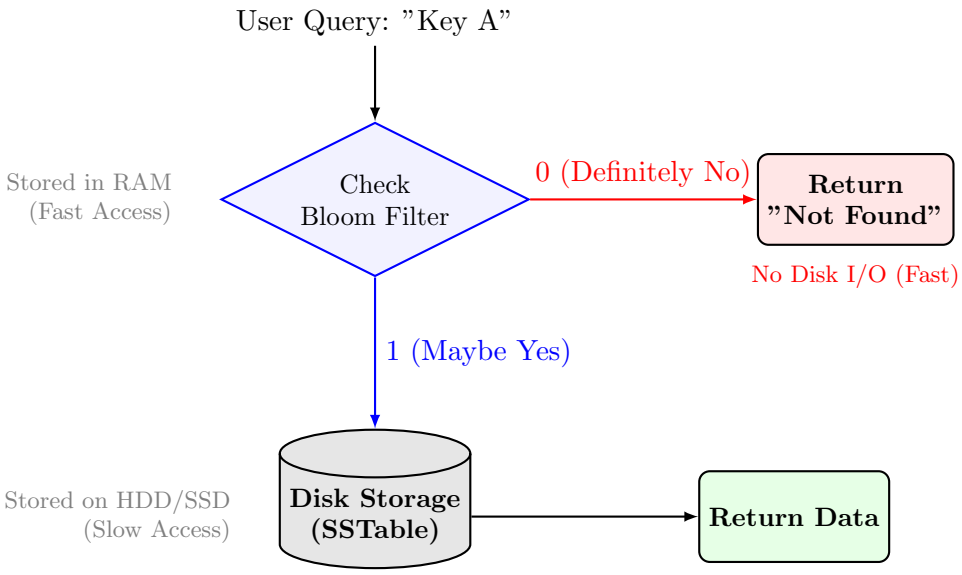


Figure 9: Bloom Filters in Log-Structured Merge (LSM) Trees (e.g., RocksDB, Cassandra). The Bloom filter acts as a gatekeeper in memory. Most lookups for non-existent keys are stopped at the filter step, preventing expensive disk I/O operations.

6.2 Blockchain Light Clients and SPV

This application is especially useful pedagogically because it shows that Bloom-filter false positives are not merely tolerated; they can be deliberately exploited to trade bandwidth for privacy.

6.2.1 The Ecosystem: Full Nodes vs. Light Nodes

In blockchain networks like Bitcoin, participation is tiered based on resource availability. The network relies on **Full Nodes**, which maintain the complete, append-only ledger of all historical transactions (often hundreds of gigabytes). Full nodes independently verify every block, transaction signature, and consensus rule, ensuring the network's security without trusting third parties [11].

However, running a full node is impractical for resource-constrained devices like mobile phones or embedded IoT systems. To address this, the ecosystem supports **Light Nodes** (or Simplified Payment Verification - SPV clients). These clients download only the block headers—a tiny fraction of the data—and rely on connected Full Nodes to retrieve specific transaction data relevant to their own wallets [11].

6.2.2 The Privacy-Bandwidth Dilemma

This reliance on Full Nodes creates a fundamental privacy challenge. A Light Node needs to ask a Full Node: *"Do you have any transactions for my address X?"*

- **Naive Approach 1 (Privacy Loss):** The client explicitly sends its list of addresses to the Full Node. This is bandwidth-efficient but disastrous for privacy, as the Full Node learns exactly which addresses the user owns and controls.
- **Naive Approach 2 (Bandwidth Loss):** The client downloads *every* transaction (like a Full Node) and filters them locally. This preserves privacy but defeats the purpose of being a "Light" node.

6.2.3 The Solution: Bloom Filter Filtering

Bloom filters solve this dilemma by allowing Light Clients to request relevant data with a tunable degree of obfuscation. The mechanism, standardized as BIP 37 [11], works as follows:

1. **Filter Construction:** The Light Client creates a Bloom filter containing its addresses, public keys, and transaction IDs. Crucially, the client tunes the filter's false positive rate (p) to balance privacy and bandwidth.
2. **Transmission:** The client sends this Bloom filter to a remote Full Node.
3. **Server-Side Filtering:** The Full Node scans new transactions and historical blocks against the filter.
4. **Data Retrieval:** If a transaction matches the filter, the Full Node sends it to the client.

6.2.4 False Positives as a Feature

In this context, Bloom filter false positives are not merely an error rate to be minimized; they are a privacy feature. Because the filter allows false positives, the Full Node returns transactions that actually belong to the client *mixed with* irrelevant transactions that coincidentally matched the filter.

This creates **plausible deniability**. The Full Node cannot distinguish which returned transactions truly belong to the client and which are false positives. By adjusting the filter parameters, the Light Client can effectively "dial in" its desired level of privacy: a denser filter (higher false positive rate) provides more camouflage at the cost of higher bandwidth (downloading more irrelevant transactions), while a sparser filter saves bandwidth but leaks more information about the user's specific interests [11].

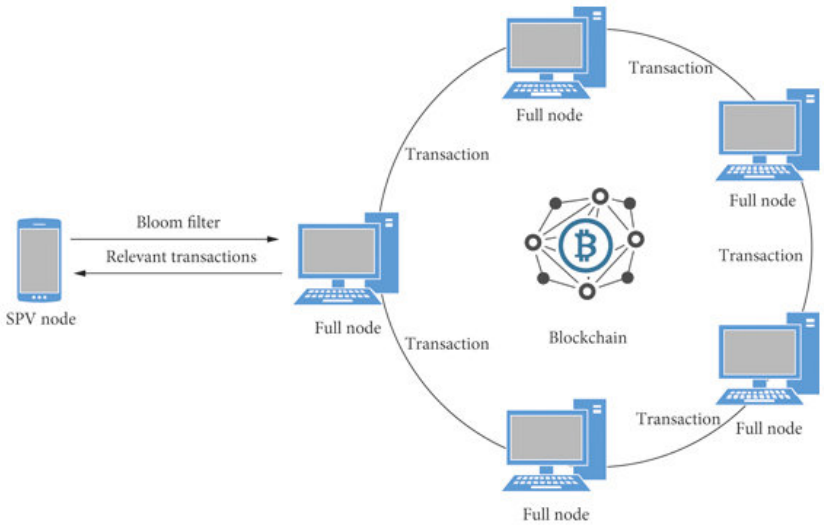


Figure 10: The architecture of SPV (Simplified Payment Verification). The SPV node (Light Client) sends a Bloom filter to a Full Node. The Full Node queries the blockchain ledger and returns only the relevant transactions that match the filter, preserving the client's privacy and bandwidth.

6.3 Cybersecurity and Intrusion Detection

Bloom filters have been proposed as an efficient solution for high-speed signature-based intrusion detection by serving as fast probabilistic pre-filters in the IDS pipeline. In this approach, an intrusion detection system maintains one or more Bloom filters encoding known attack signatures and scans packet payloads for potential matches. If a Bloom filter indicates a match, the corresponding traffic is forwarded for verification, while non-matching traffic is safely discarded. This design significantly reduces the computational load of expensive pattern-matching stages and enables high-throughput detection at multi-gigabit rates. Although false positives may cause benign traffic to undergo further analysis, Bloom filters introduce no false negatives, a property that is critical in security applications. Overall, Bloom-filter–based pre-filtering provides a scalable and memory-efficient mechanism for intrusion detection systems [7].

7 Algorithm Implementation

This section presents a reference implementation of an optimal Bloom filter. The implementation follows the theoretical analysis presented earlier and automatically derives the optimal filter parameters from the expected number of elements.

Unless stated otherwise, the false-positive probability is set to $p = 0.01$, a commonly used default in practical systems.

Listing 1: Bloom Filter Implementation

```
import math
import mmh3
from bitarray import bitarray


class BloomFilter:
    """
    Optimal Bloom Filter with default false-positive probability p = 0.01
    """

    DEFAULT_FP_PROB = 0.01

    def __init__(self, items_count, fp_prob=None):
        """
        items_count : expected number of inserted elements (n)
        fp_prob     : desired false positive probability (p),
                      defaults to 0.01 if not provided
        """

        if items_count <= 0:
            raise ValueError("items_count must be > 0")

        self.fp_prob = fp_prob if fp_prob is not None else self.
           DEFAULT_FP_PROB

        if not (0 < self.fp_prob < 1):
            raise ValueError("fp_prob must be between 0 and 1")

        self.n = items_count
```

```
29
30          # Optimal parameters
31          self.size = self._optimal_size(self.n, self.fp_prob)
32          self.hash_count = self._optimal_hash_count(self.size, self.n)
33
34          # Bit array initialization
35          self.bit_array = bitarray(self.size)
36          self.bit_array.setall(False)
37
38      def add(self, item):
39          for i in range(self.hash_count):
40              digest = mmh3.hash(item, i, signed=False) % self.size
41              self.bit_array[digest] = True
42
43      def check(self, item):
44          for i in range(self.hash_count):
45              digest = mmh3.hash(item, i, signed=False) % self.size
46              if not self.bit_array[digest]:
47                  return False
48          return True
49
50      @staticmethod
51      def _optimal_size(n, p):
52          """
53          m = -(n * ln p) / (ln 2)^2
54          """
55          return math.ceil(-(n * math.log(p)) / (math.log(2) ** 2))
56
57      @staticmethod
58      def _optimal_hash_count(m, n):
59          """
60          k = (m / n) * ln 2
61          """
62          return max(1, math.ceil((m / n) * math.log(2)))
```

8 Conclusion

Bloom filters exemplify the enduring power of probabilistic algorithms in computer science. By accepting a controllable degree of error specifically, one-sided false positives systems can achieve space efficiencies that are impossible with deterministic data structures. As this paper has demonstrated, the utility of Bloom filters has evolved far beyond their original application.

In modern networked systems, they serve as critical infrastructure. In distributed databases like Cassandra and RocksDB, they bridge the latency gap between memory and disk, preventing expensive I/O operations. In networking, they enable scalable queue management and loop detection without the prohibitive cost of maintaining per-flow state. Most recently, in blockchain ecosystems, they have been repurposed to solve privacy and bandwidth challenges for light clients, turning their probabilistic nature into a feature for plausible deniability.

Ultimately, as data scales continue to outpace memory capacities, the guiding principle articulated by Broder and Mitzenmacher remains vital: wherever exactness is expensive and space is constrained, the Bloom filter offers a near-optimal solution. Their theoretical elegance, combined with their adaptability to new domains, ensures their continued relevance.

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